The Unofficial Okafor Lab FAQ

Written by lab members for lab members. Started by Kavya Thomas (PhD 2024) in 2021. Last big edit May 2025 (Hannah L., Daniel O.); a few small edits in August 2025.

> **Heads up:** this is not an official document, and some of it may be out of date. If anything here disagrees with Marisol's or Tomasz's documents, *theirs win*. Please fix this page if you spot something stale!

Q: Where do I get dry ice on a weekday?

The stockroom in the basement (B12). They're open until 6, so you can grab it on your way out. Bring a styrofoam box; they don't give you one. *(KT, updated DO)*

Q: How do I book the ultracentrifuge?

Just write your name and times on the paper sign-up sheet taped to the side of the ultra. Daniel checks it every morning. AND FILL IN THE ROTOR LOG. Seriously. Daniel will find you. *(DO)*

Q: Can I do tissue culture late at night?

The unwritten rule has been that it's fine until about 10 pm as long as you post in the lab group chat that you're in TC. After 10, find someone to hang around. *(KT)*

Q: When is lab meeting?

Tuesdays at 4 pm in 418A. There are usually snacks. Journal club is every other week. *(HL)*

Q: Where can I eat lunch?

In 417 (the desk room). It's the only room in the suite where food is allowed. Never in 412, 413, 415 or 416, not even "just a coffee". The fifth-floor lounge has a microwave. *(HL)*

Q: Which pipettes can I use when I start?

The shared set in the top drawer in 412 with green tape on it. After a few weeks Marisol assigns you your own set. Please put the green-tape ones back. *(SM)*

Q: The -80 is full and I have samples. Where do they go?

Not on someone else's shelf (people have lost friendships over this). Ask Marisol; she usually finds you space in Freezer C for a while. *(DO)*

Q: Is the cold room a good place to keep dry ice for a few hours?

NO. It's a closed room and the CO_2 builds up. Tomasz will explain this very patiently and then very impatiently. *(HL)*

Q: The plate reader software crashed mid-run.

Restart the PC (not the reader), reopen your protocol and message Aisha. Don't reinstall anything. *(AB)*

Q: How do I get oligos?

The Oligo Core in the Sato Center, through their web form. Standard ones arrive the next day in their pick-up fridge. Don't order them from vendors yourself; Marisol will be sad. *(RC)*

Q: Is there a coffee situation?

There's a coffee machine in 417. The coffee fund is $10 a month, paid to Hannah. Descaling it is not on the official chore rota, but it should be. *(HL)*

Q: Who do I ask when I don't know who to ask?

Marisol for anything admin or supplies, Tomasz for anything safety, your mentor for anything science. Nobody minds questions. *(KT)*

Q: Any advice for the first month?

Do your trainings early (the BSL-2 in-person session fills up fast). Write things in the ELN the same day, because future-you will not remember. Label everything. Go to the subgroup meetings even if you think you have nothing to show. *(HL, DO, RC)*